



Grails

An Agile and Friendly Framework

Grails is an open source Web application framework for the Java Virtual Machine. In this article, the author introduces developers to the 'holy grail' in software—the Grails Framework.

In the competitive world of start-ups and business expansion, a software developer is always hunting for the best technology to build applications faster. This article is an introduction to Grails, which according to Wikipedia, "... is an open source Web application framework that uses the Groovy programming language (which is in turn based on the Java platform)." If you have never worked with Groovy before, you shouldn't worry because standard Java language constructs work as is, in Groovy. And if you know scripting languages like Python or Ruby, you will find that Groovy is very intuitive and simple to use. Another obvious reason to use Grails is that it provides built-in support for well-developed Java technologies like Spring and Hibernate, which makes migrating from a Java stack to Grails a very painless and simple process. Being a Web framework, it uses the well-tested MVC design paradigm. Quoting Wikipedia again, some of the other key features of Grails is that it offers documentation for key portions of the framework like:

- The Persistence framework
- Templates using GSP (Groovy Server Pages)
- Dynamic tag libraries for creating Web page components
- Customisable and extensible Ajax support

As a consequence, Grails is one of the most productive amongst frameworks.

Getting started

To get started with Grails on a Linux machine, follow the steps shown below. I am using Ubuntu 12.04, so in case

you're using another distro, you can easily adapt the following steps accordingly.

1. **Installing JDK:** On Ubuntu, you can type the following command into the terminal to install the JDK.

```
sudo apt-get install openjdk-6-jdk
```

You can alternatively use the Sun version of Java as well, but use version 6 of the OpenJDK for maximum compatibility with Grails.

2. **Installing GVM (Groovy enVironment Manager):** The GVM is a command line tool that helps you manage different versions of the SDK on UNIX systems. Using GVM, you can install multiple versions of Grails and Switch easily. Let's install GVM by first using *curl* (a UNIX tool used to download files) to get the GVM script and then execute it. So before starting, ensure you have *curl* installed on your system by using the following command.

```
sudo apt-get install curl
```

After running the above command, you can use the following command to download the GVM script and execute it.

```
curl -s get.gvmtool.net | bash
```

After the script completes, you will be asked to open a